

SD FC Pricing Intelligence Platform

Executive Summary | VP of Data Analytics & Strategy

28,064
2025 Avg Attendance

\$796K
2025 Revenue Left on Table

+11.4%
Revenue Uplift (Balanced)

\$204
STH Net Resale Value/Seat

The Problem

San Diego FC completed its inaugural 2025 season averaging 28,064 fans per game in a 35,000-seat Snapdragon Stadium. Ticket prices were set once before the season using gut feel and competitor benchmarks. The secondary market told a different story: Baja Cup matches against Club Tijuana cleared at 40-58% above face value, while midweek games against weaker opponents sat below face. An estimated \$796,000 in revenue was left on the table in Year 1 and that number grows as the market matures.

The Solution

A machine learning platform that recommends optimal ticket prices for every section and every game, grounded in what fans are actually willing to pay. It combines demand forecasting (XGBoost), causal price elasticity (Double Machine Learning), and airline-style yield optimization (EMSR-b) calibrated against verified 2025 attendance data. Backtesting shows the Balanced scenario would have generated +11.4% revenue uplift versus the flat pricing used in 2025.

The platform outputs three pricing scenarios per section per game:

- Conservative: minimal price movement, targets 90%+ fill rate, lowest risk
- Balanced (recommended): optimizes revenue while protecting season ticket holder resale margins
- Aggressive: maximum revenue extraction for confirmed high-demand games only

Every recommendation includes a plain-English explanation: "Section 111 is \$8 below optimal. Drivers: rivalry game (+\$8), high secondary demand (+\$5), Saturday night (+\$3)."

What Makes It Different

- **Causal, not correlated** -- isolates the true effect of price on demand, controlling for opponent quality, weather, and timing
- **Explainable** -- every recommendation comes with reasons your ticketing team can understand and challenge
- **Guardrailed** -- STH net resale margins protected by design (primary never exceeds secondary minus ~10% marketplace fees); any increase above 25% flagged for manual review
- **Three choices, not one** -- management picks the risk level, the model handles the math

Implementation Path

Phase	Timeline	What Happens
Phase 1	Now	Offline recommendations. Run model before each pricing window, present scenarios, manually update Archtics.
Phase 2	3-6 months	API integration with Ticketmaster Host for automated price updates with human approval gate.
Phase 3	6-12 months	Real-time feedback loop with live sell-through tracking and mid-season recalibration.

First 90 Days

Days 1-30: Replace synthetic data with real Archtics/CRM feeds. Validate model accuracy on real transaction data.

Days 31-60: First live pricing recommendations for early-season home games. A/B test: control vs model-priced section groups. Dashboard live for ticketing team.

Days 61-90: First measurable results. Revenue uplift report. STH health validation. Phase 2 roadmap presented.

Built with Python, XGBoost, DuckDB, Streamlit, FastAPI, SHAP | Data: FBref, SeatGeek, StubHub, Vivid Seats, OddsPortal, MLS Official, Ticketmaster